EXECUTIVE SUMMARY · STEAM LAUNCH HEALTH · FOR THE HEAD OF PUBLISHING

A healthy launch is decided in two days. The warning signs come later and they're easy to miss.

What does a healthy first 90 days on Steam look like for games like ours, and which early signals warn us that the rating is going wrong?

> **Bottom line:** by day 2 you already know roughly where a game's overall Steam score will end up. What you don't know yet is whether it will hold. Watch the **rolling 7-day score**, the **first two hours of play** and **Chinese players**. That's where launches go wrong.

754,026
Steam reviews, days 0–90

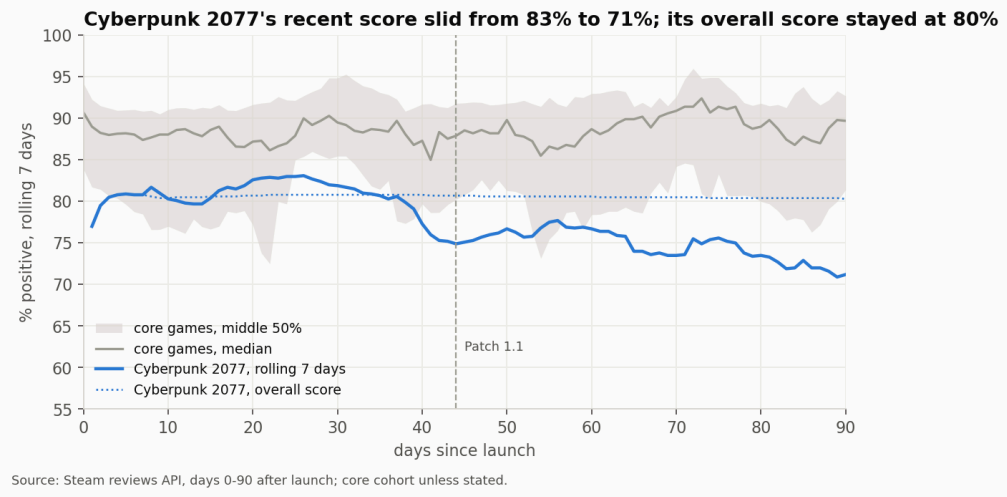
23
Polish-made games, 2018–2025 (20 similar to ours, 3 benchmarks)

±2.9 pts
how closely days 0–1 forecast the rest of the quarter

~6,500
more negative Chinese reviews than each game's own rate predicts

WHAT WE FOUND

1. **The overall score is set almost immediately, so it can't warn you.** For 18 of 20 games, week 1 was within 5 points of the rest of the quarter (r = 0.94). Yet the most recent 30 days still moved by 5+ points for 9 of 20 games, and 5 of those moves were down. Steam shows players that recent score separately.



Source: Steam reviews API, days 0-90 after launch; core cohort unless stated.

2. **Unhappy players leave inside the refund window.** Reviewers with under 2 hours played are 20 points less positive than the rest (65% vs ~85%). For Cooking Simulator, Chernobylite and Green Hell, half of all negatives come from them. Short games are judged early; long games collect their negatives after 20 hours.

3. **China is the least happy large market, and translation isn't the cause.** Chinese players rate games a median of 6.4 points below the game's own score, and 11 of 20 games are more than 5 points below. Only 1.9% of Chinese negatives mention translation; performance (26%) and servers (12%) are the real complaints.

WHAT TO DO

- **Day 2:** read the overall score and set it as the baseline.
- **Days 3–90:** track the rolling 7-day score. Escalate if it is **5+ points below** the baseline.
- **Before launch:** polish the first two hours (tutorial, onboarding, first-session performance), especially for short games.
- **China:** budget for performance testing, server capacity and local community management, not just translation.

WHAT NOT TO COUNT ON

- **The first patch.** In the 14 days after it, the score rose for 11 games and fell for 12 (median −0.2 pts). It does reduce performance complaints, which fell in 15 of 23 games.
- **Week-1 complaints as a guide to later ones.** Performance and server complaints fade (30%→21%, 23%→10%); complaints about content and story don't.

Data: Steam's public Web API, all languages and purchase types, 7 days before to 90 days after launch (99.97% of Steam's own count). Limitations: Steam PC only; review verdicts are as they stand today (19.9% were edited); keyword themes are indicative; 20 core games is a small sample; patch effects are before/after with no control group. Full method, SQL, notebook and Power BI dashboard: github.com/Qba99/launch-health-of-polish-made-games-on-steam · Jakub Siuda